

PORTRAYING SOCIETY

ARTISTIC STRATEGIES FOR SEEING OURSELVES

Polina Rud

1. FLATTERY: WHO SOCIETY WANTS TO BELIEVE IT IS

- Why do societies need flattering images?
- From pharaohs to Instagram influencers, what hasn't changed? How images teach us who we are and who we should want to become.
- When and why does art stop representing reality and start creating it?

2. DIAGNOSIS: WHAT SOCIETY CANNOT ADMIT ABOUT ITSELF

- Artistic strategies to diagnose social symptoms and reveal its hidden structures and contradictions.
- How those structures become habits, language, gestures, memory, and identity

3. STAGING: CREATING THE CONDITIONS UNDER WHICH SOCIETY REVEALS ITSELF

- Why and how artists create the conditions under which society reveals itself.
- How participation, conflict, conversation, and even exploitation become artistic materials.

FLATTERY

WHO SOCIETY WANTS TO BELIEVE IT IS



Reason is a very inadequate term with which to comprehend the forms of man's cultural life in all their richness and variety. But all these forms are symbolic forms. Hence, instead of defining man as an animal rationale we should define him as an animal symbolicum.

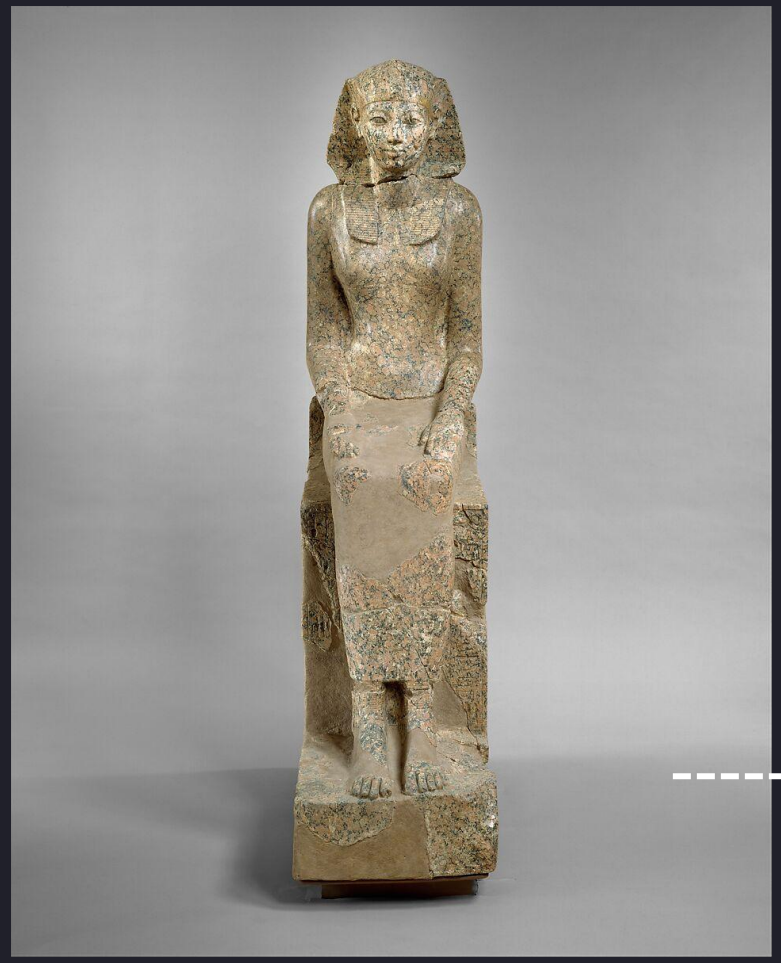
Ernst Cassirer

an animal symbolicum

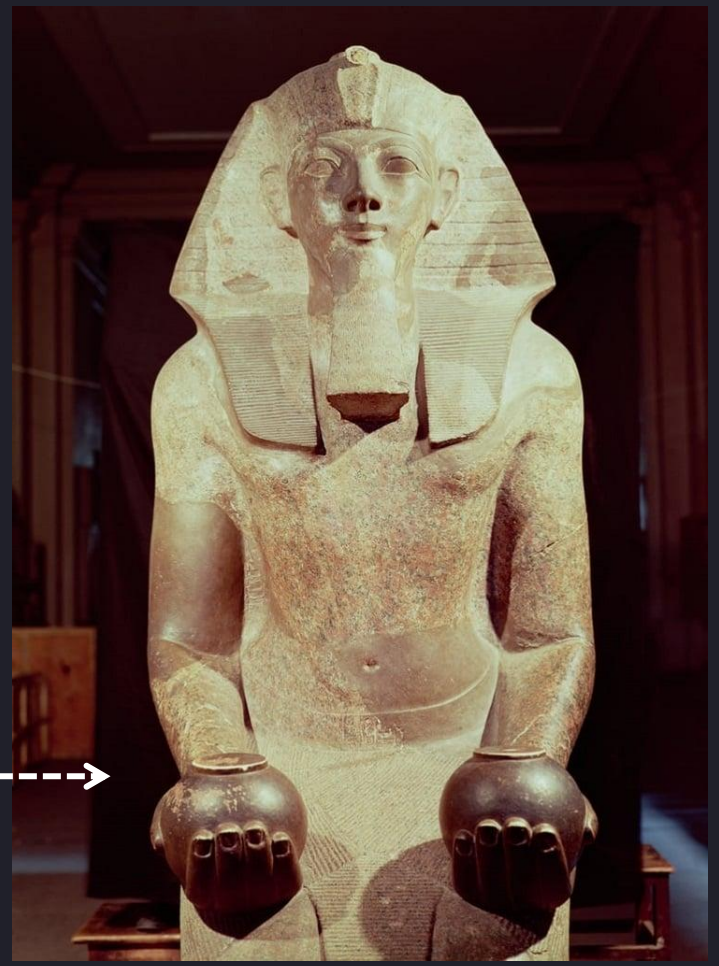


The king has in him two bodies: a body natural, and a body politic.

Ernst Kantorowicz

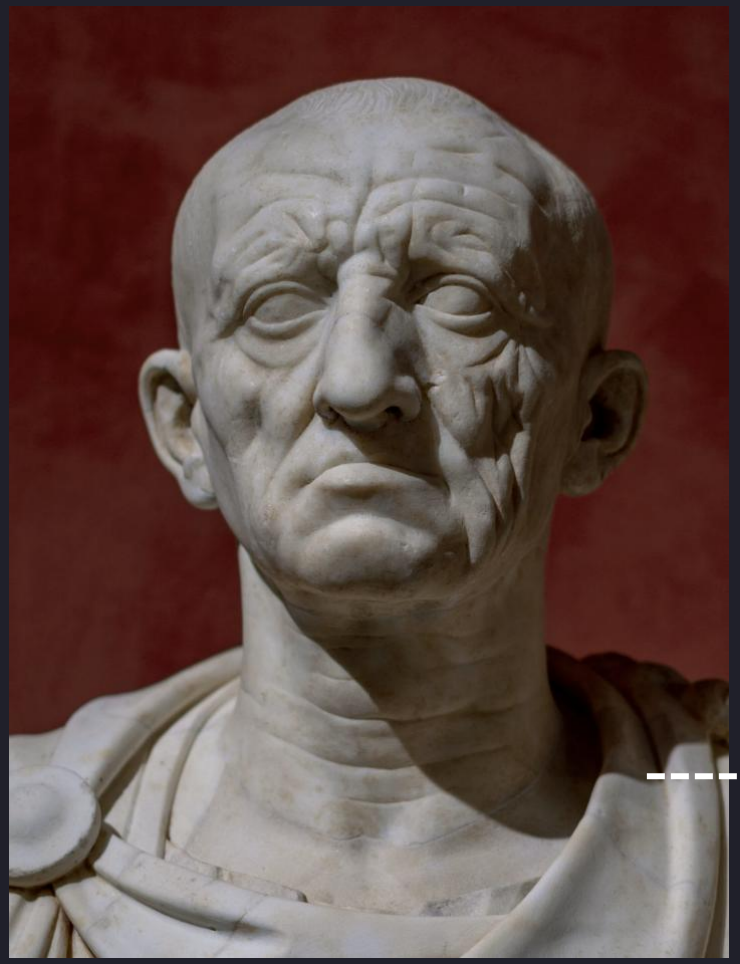


The Female Pharaoh Hatshepsut, The Metropolitan Museum of Art, New York.



Kneeling statue of Hatshepsut making an offering of Nu vases. Egyptian Museum, Cairo.

The political image proved more important than the biological body.



Head of a Roman Patrician from Otricoli, marble, Palazzo Torlonia, Rome



Caesar Augustus, marble statue; Vatican Museums.

Flattery is not about making someone more beautiful. It is about making them embody what a society should value most.

Portrait of Henry VIII of England, Hans Holbein the Younger, ca. 1537, Museo Nacional Thyssen-Bornemisza, Madrid



Queen Elizabeth (after Zuchero), Henry Bone (1755-1834), Kingston Lacy, Dorset



"Mask of Youth“ to preserve the political body



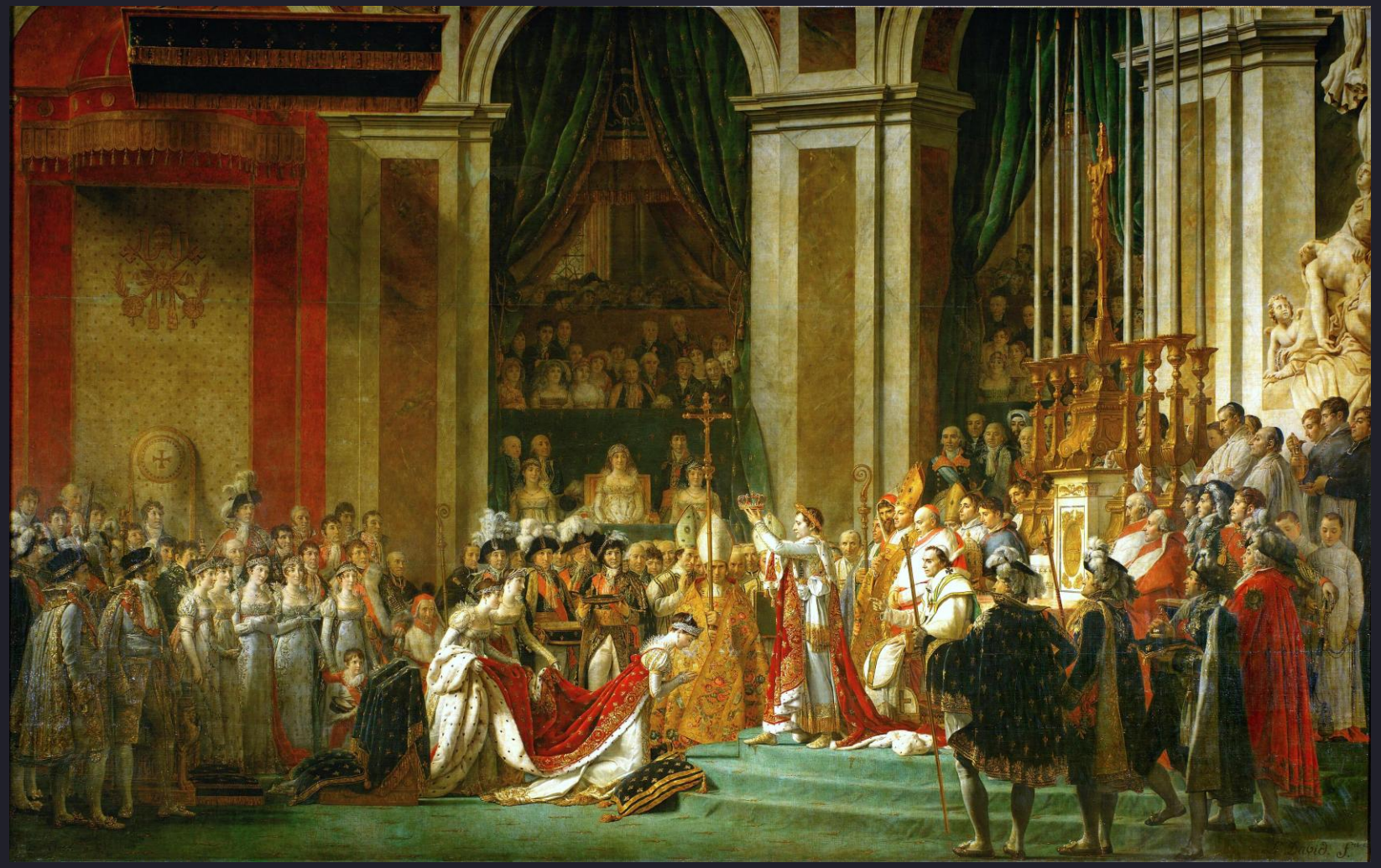
Napoleon Crossing the Alps, Jacques-Louis David
Château de Malmaison



Napoleon Bonaparte Crossing the Alps, Hippolyte Delaroche, Louvre







The Coronation of Napoleon, Jacques-Louis David, Louvre

The new emperor/ people (?) wanted to believe that the Revolution had produced not chaos, but a strong and legitimate new order.



Castas paintings invited viewers to believe that colonial hierarchy was not the product of domination, but the natural, enlightened organization of society.



Yuri Pimenov, Long Live Heavy Industry! 1927, State Tretyakov Gallery.



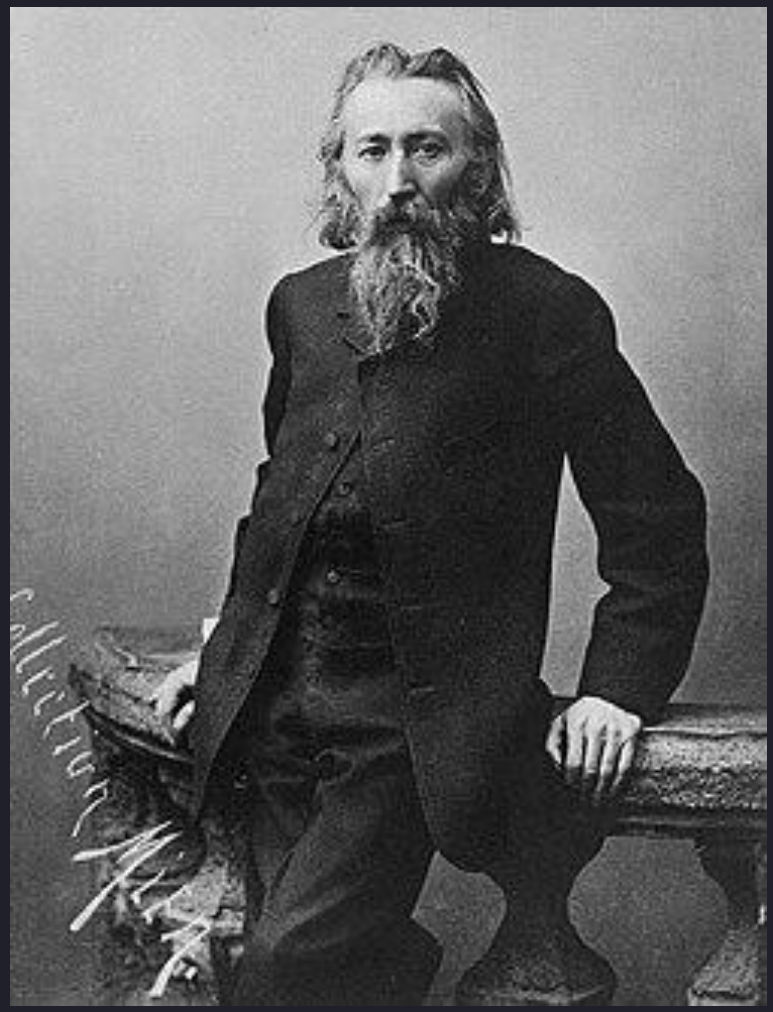
Aleksandr Deyneka, Peaceful Construction Projects. 1959–1960, The State Russian Museum, Mikhailovsky Palace

Socialist Realism represented an orchestrated visual optimism



Norman Rockwell, Four Freedom. Left to right: Freedom from Want, Freedom of Speech, Freedom of Worship, Freedom from Fear





Jan Matejko, Constitution of 3 May 1791

Nations are imagined communities built through shared symbols, images, and historical memory

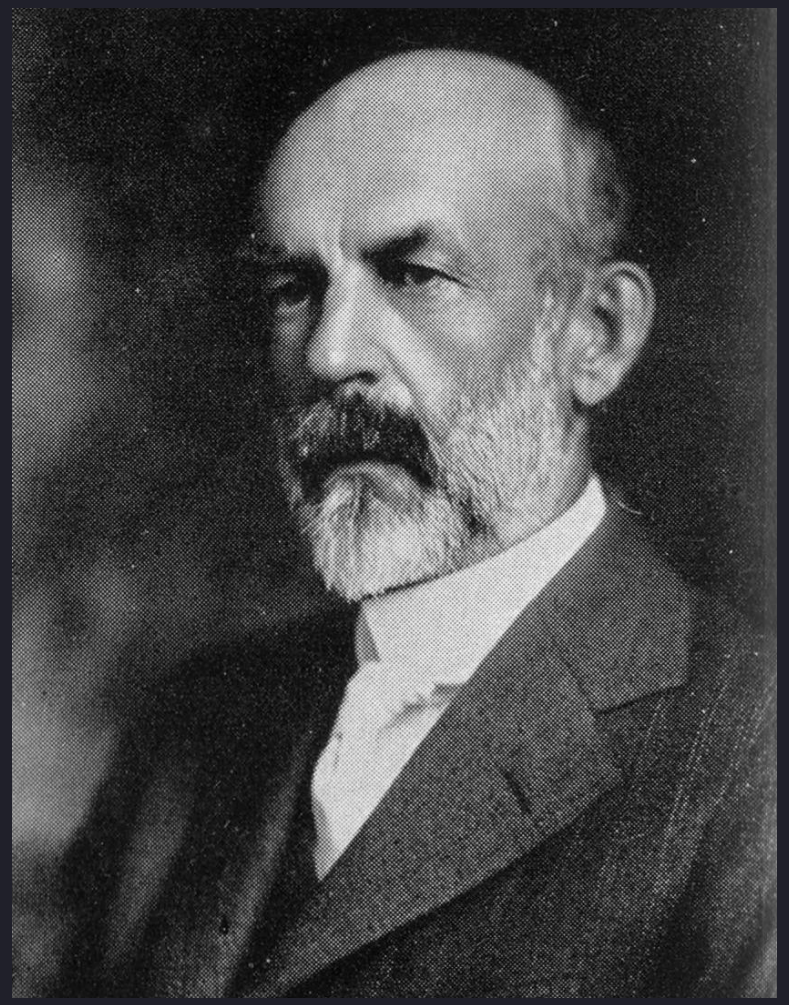


The bloodlines of Indigenous, White, Black, and Asian peoples would unite in the Americas to form a new and superior race – the Fifth race.

José Vasconcielos



Diego Rivera, Agrarian leader Zapata, 1931



I am not what I think I am, and I am not what you think I am; I am what I think you think I am.

Charles Horton Cooley





Yasumasa Morimura, Self-Portraits through Art History, since 1985

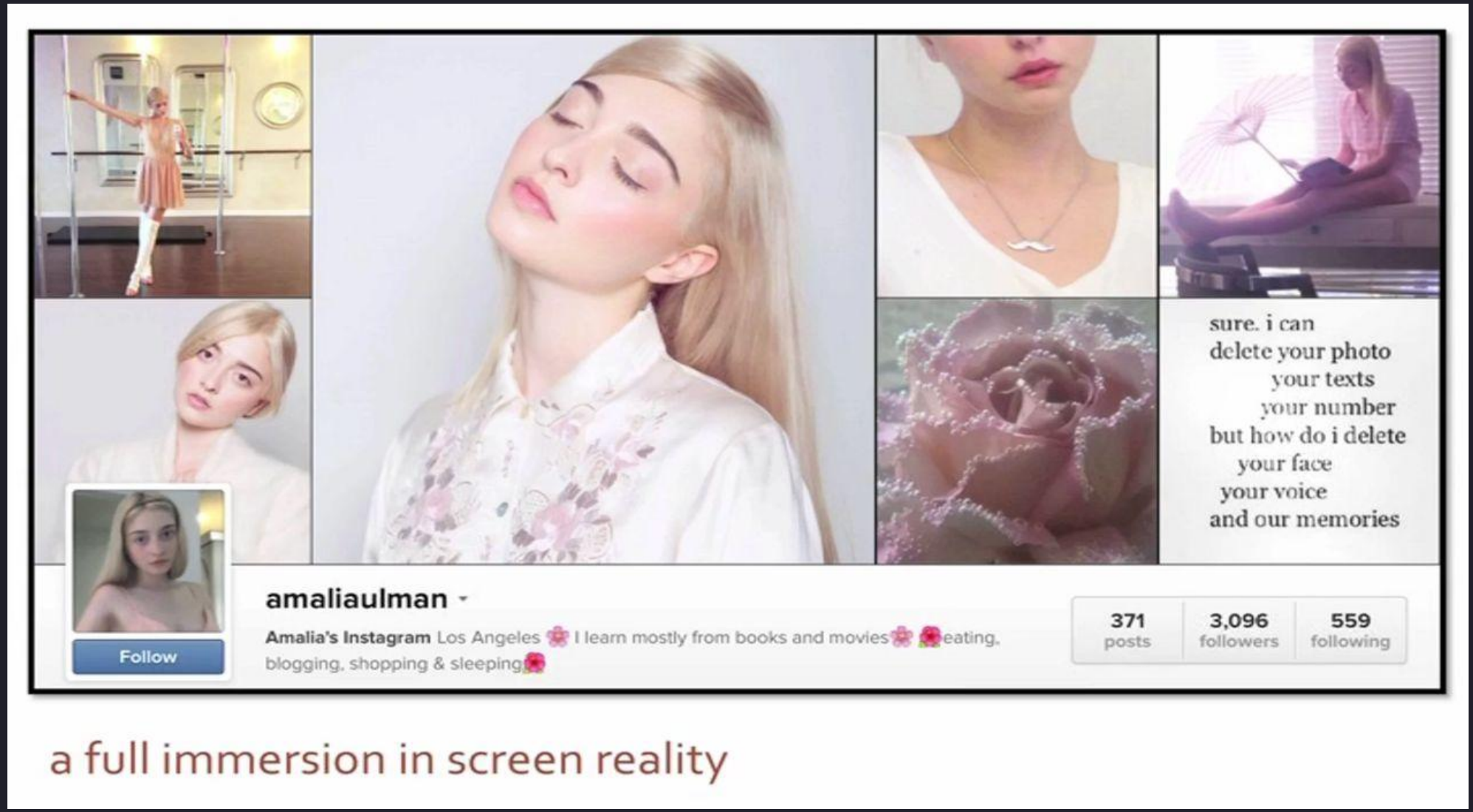
If I place myself inside the masterpiece, does some of its prestige, legitimacy, and historical force become mine?





Martin Parr

Pierre Bourdieu’s Distinction shows that taste is never innocent; it is one of the main ways social identity is produced, classified, and put on display.



a full immersion in screen reality

Amalia Ulman, Excellences & Perfections, 2014

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Flattery as world-building: art gives reality a coherent, reassuring shape, turning uncertainty and contradiction into something people can believe in and live with (Cassirer).
- From ruler to nation to self: the mechanism scales up over time starting with flattering individual bodies of power (pharaohs, emperors, kings), expanding into flattering whole social orders (colonial hierarchies, national ideologies), and finally arriving at the individual flattering themselves (social media).
- Complicity: following Foucault and Bourdieu, flattering images succeed by participation since people repeat and internalize them until the constructed hierarchy feels natural, "common sense," even desirable.
- Flattery cuts both ways: the same mechanism that legitimizes oppression (Casta paintings, Socialist Realism) can also sustain dignity and identity for the powerless (Matejko's Poland, Rivera's Mexico).
- Today, we no longer only consume flattering images, we produce them ourselves.

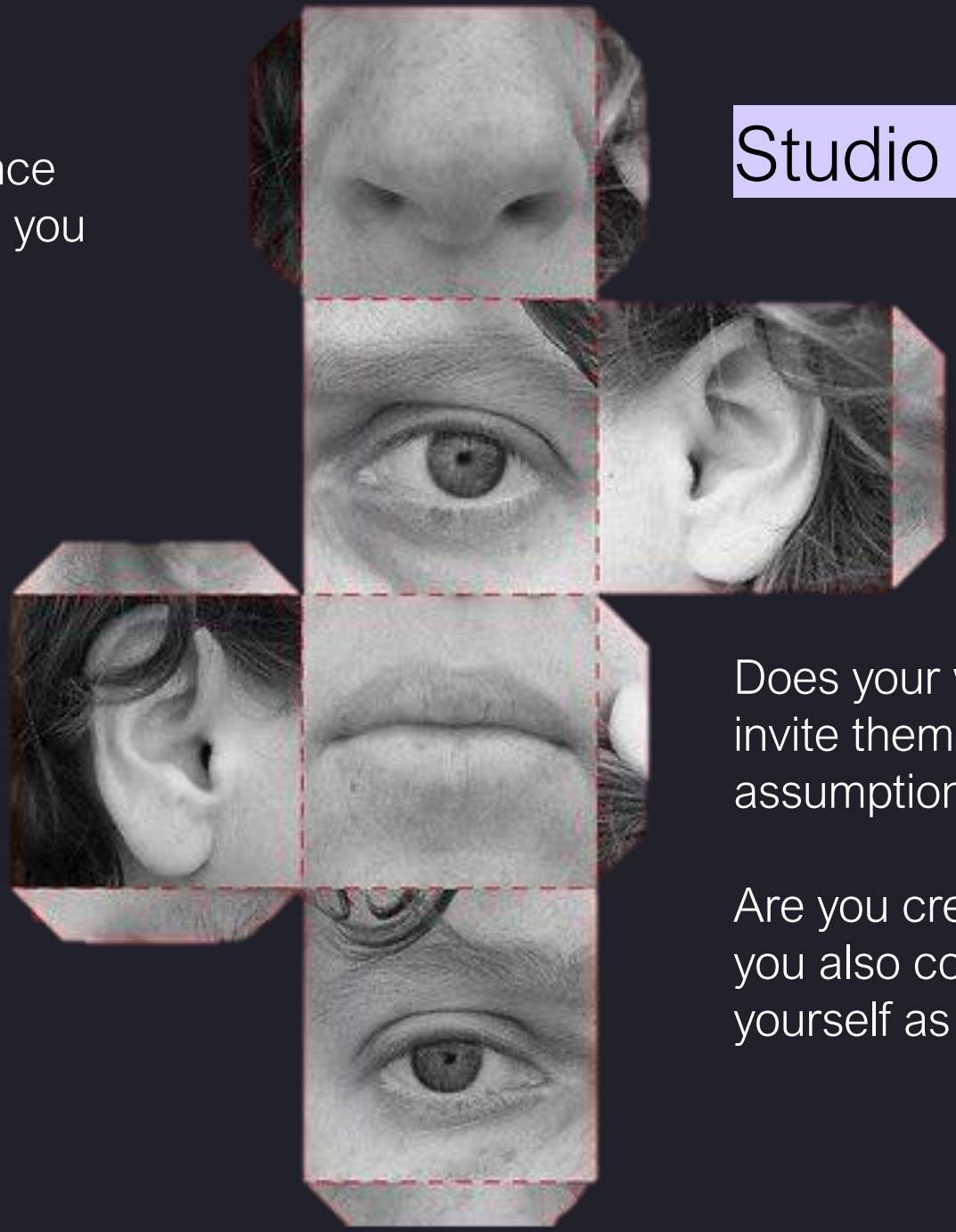
Key strategies across the examples

- The body politic vs. the mortal body (Hatshepsut, Augustus, Holbein's Henry VIII, Elizabeth's "Mask of Youth")
- Staged harmony as legitimacy (David's Napoleon)
- Taxonomy as reassurance (Casta paintings)
- Retouching history itself (Socialist Realism)
- Selective everyday life as universal ideal (Rockwell)
- Painting as national memory (Matejko)
- Replacing the hero (Rivera)
- Self-insertion as borrowed authority (Morimura)
- Self-performance as algorithmic flattery (Ulman)

Studio Reflections

What external values, expectations, or norms influence your artistic practice? How do you experience their presence?

Which values does your work reinforce? Which ones does it challenge?



Does your work reassure the viewer or invite them to question their assumptions?

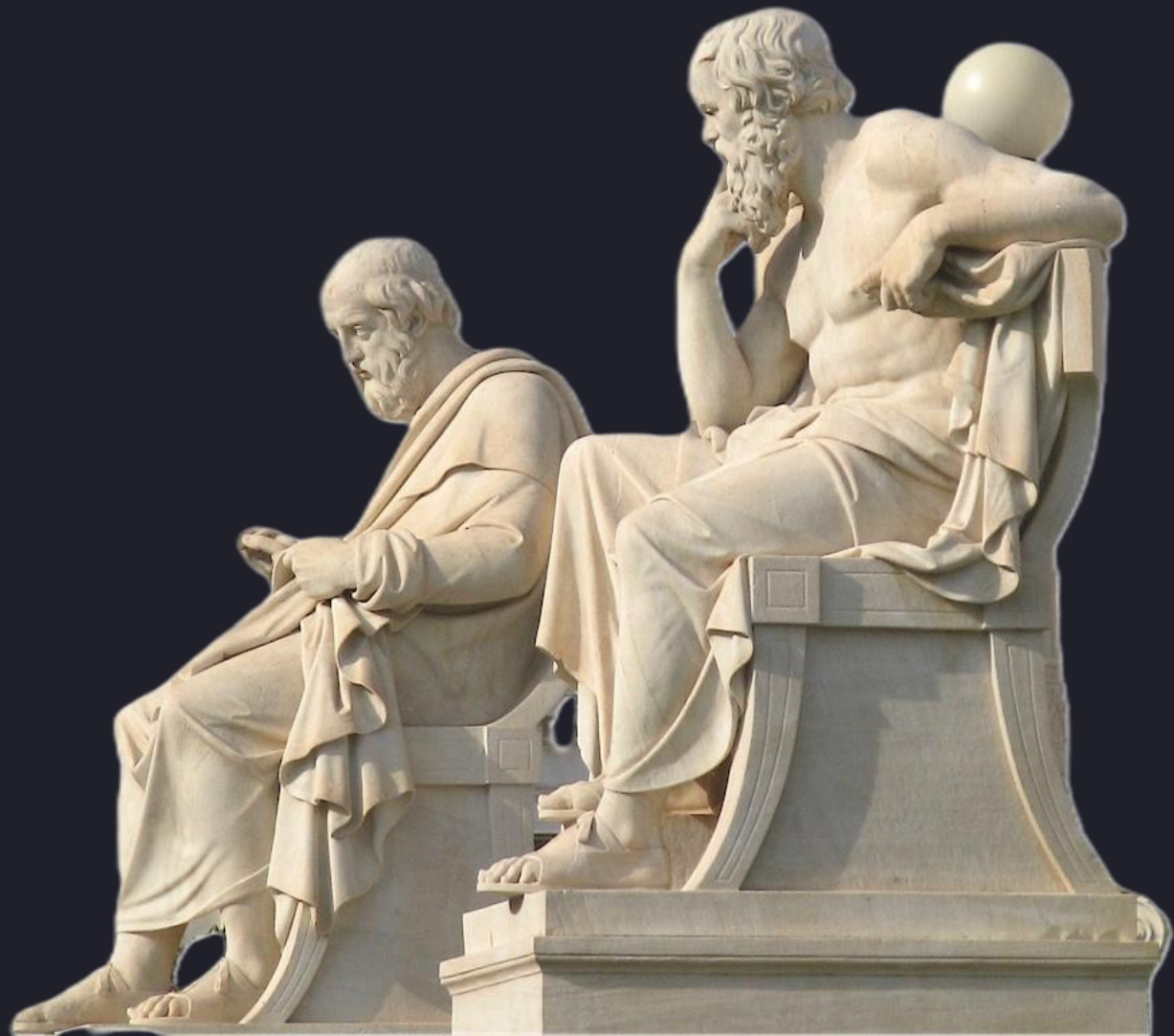
Are you creating only an artwork, or are you also constructing an identity for yourself as an artist?

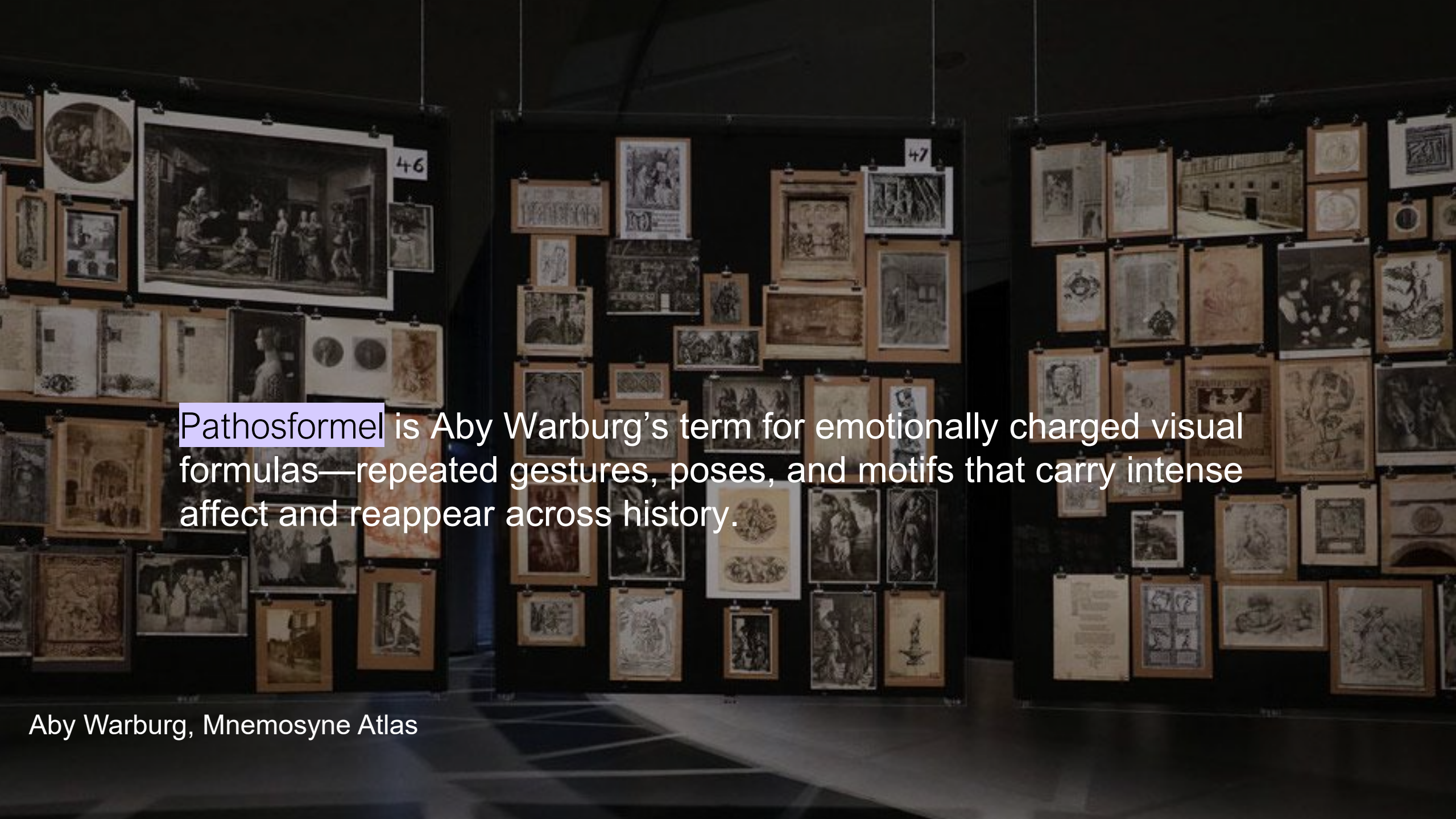
DIAGNOSIS

WHAT SOCIETY CANNOT ADMIT ABOUT ITSELF

parrhesia = speaking everything

Aristophanes through political comedy exposed the follies of Athenian democracy and public figures. In Plato's Apology, Socrates describes himself as the "gadfly" of Athens, whose role is to sting the city into self-examination.



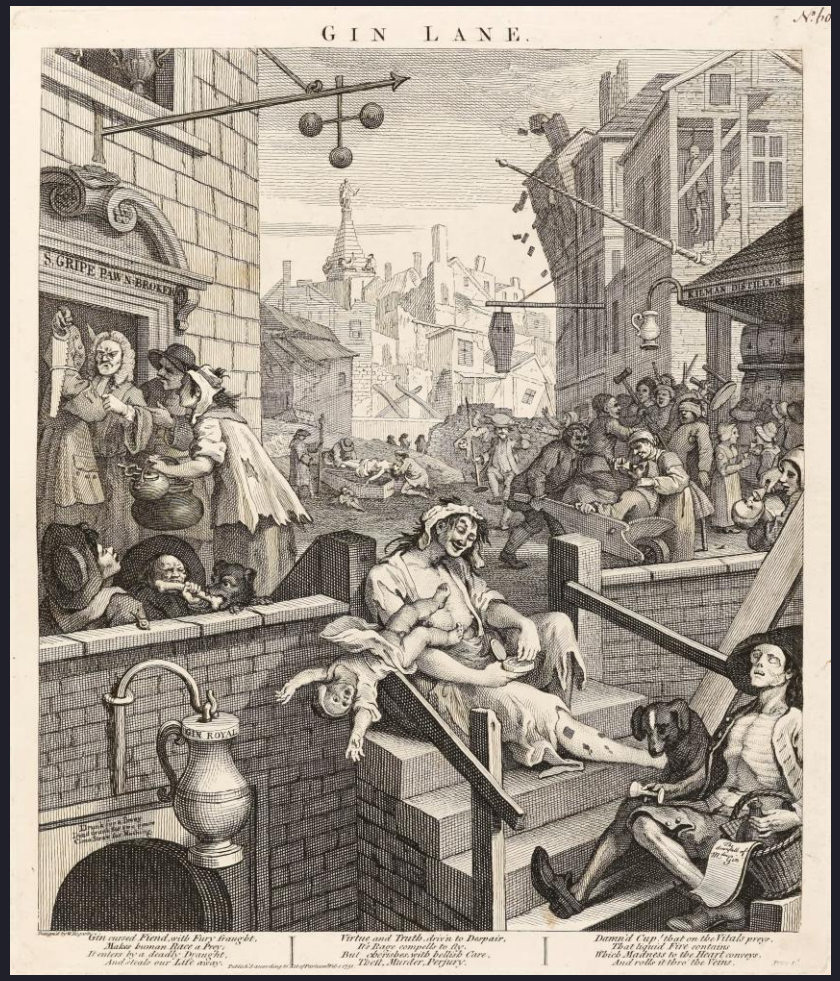


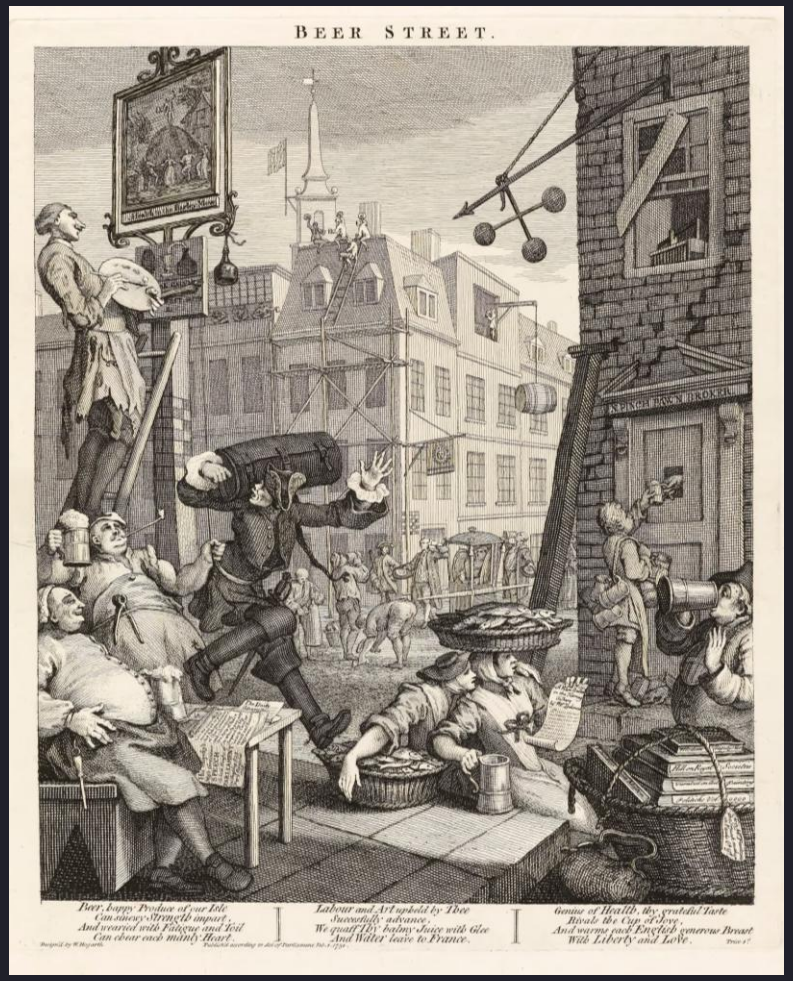
Pathosformel is Aby Warburg’s term for emotionally charged visual formulas—repeated gestures, poses, and motifs that carry intense affect and reappear across history.

Aby Warburg, Mnemosyne Atlas



Netherlandish Proverbs, Pieter Bruegel the Elder, 1559, Gemäldegalerie, Berlin





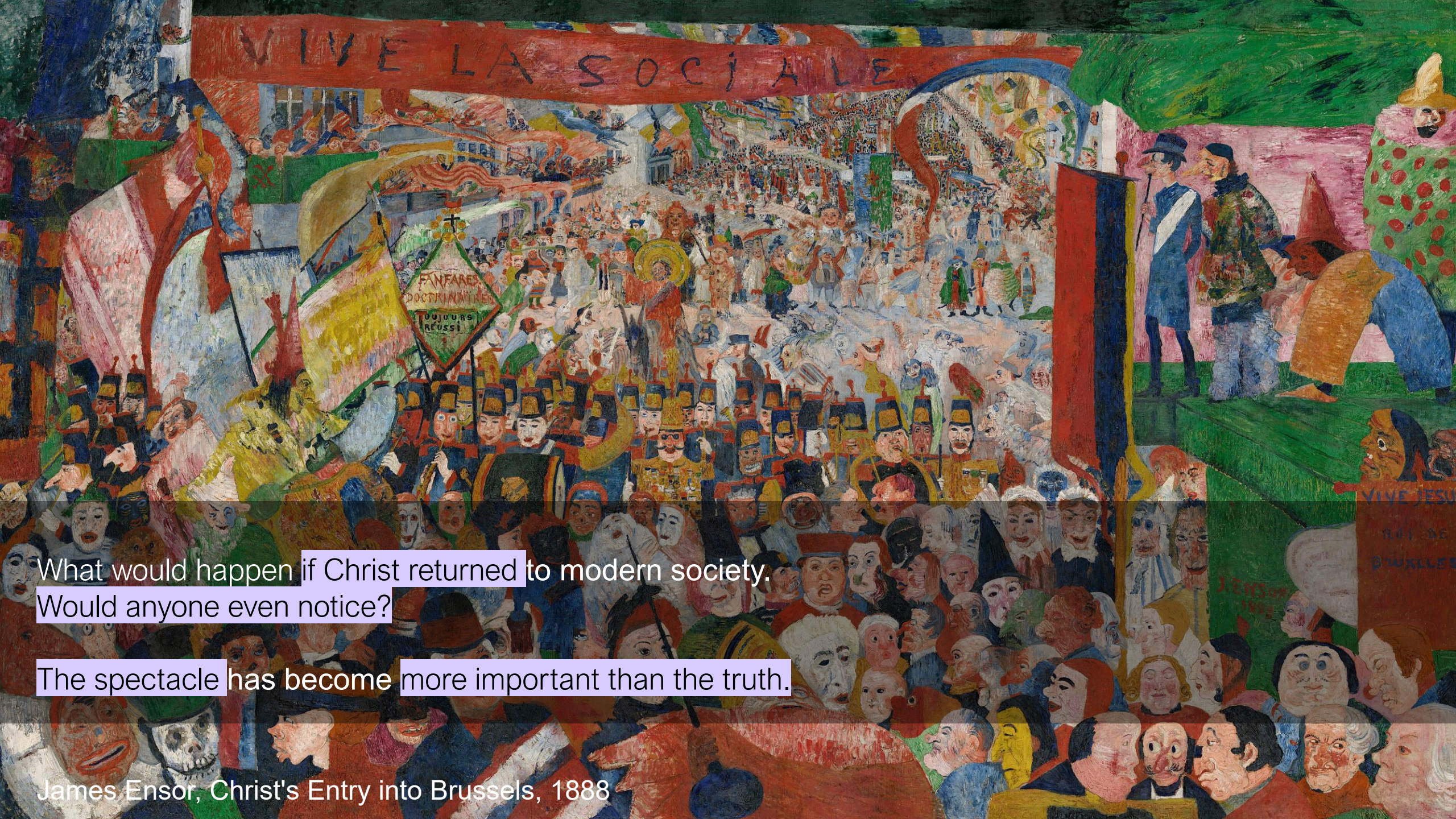
Vice flourishes within a particular social environment.

“Gin Lane”, “Beer Street”,
William Hogarth, 1751





Series Marriage A-la-Mode, William Hogarth, 1743–1745



What would happen if Christ returned to modern society.
Would anyone even notice?

The spectacle has become more important than the truth.

James Ensor, Christ's Entry into Brussels, 1888



José Guadalupe Posada, Calaveras, 1910-1912, Colección Blaisten


Death is democratic. It comes to everyone

what appears to be a personal crisis
often has social origins

the hidden networks of power are
embedded in schools, hospitals, prisons,
and bureaucracies

institutions shape
individual behavior



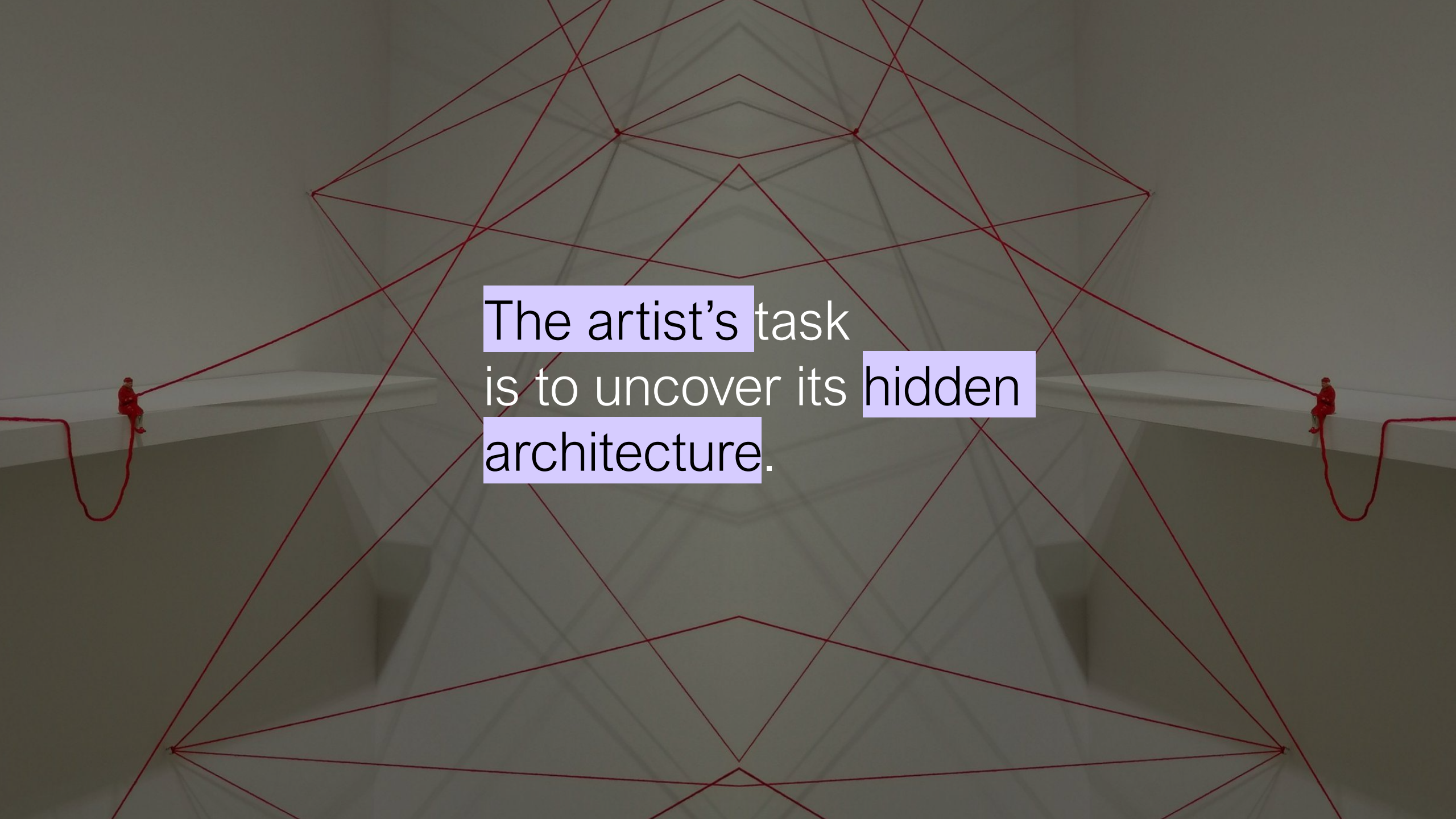
Émile Durkheim



Michel Foucault



Max Weber


The artist’s task
is to uncover its hidden
architecture.



Money was the cheapest material at the time.

Zero Cruzeiro, Cildo Meireles. 1974–1978.



Insertions into Ideological Circuits: Coca-Cola Project. Cildo Meireles. 1970–1975

Mierle Laderman Ukeles,
Maintenance
Art Manifesto,
1969



MANIFESTO!

MAINTENANCE ART -- Proposal for an Exhibition

"CARE"

©1969
Mierle Laderman Ukeles

I. IDEAS:

A. The Death Instinct and the Life Instinct:

The Death Instinct: separation, individuality, Avant-Garde par excellence; to follow one's own path to death--do your own thing, dynamic change.

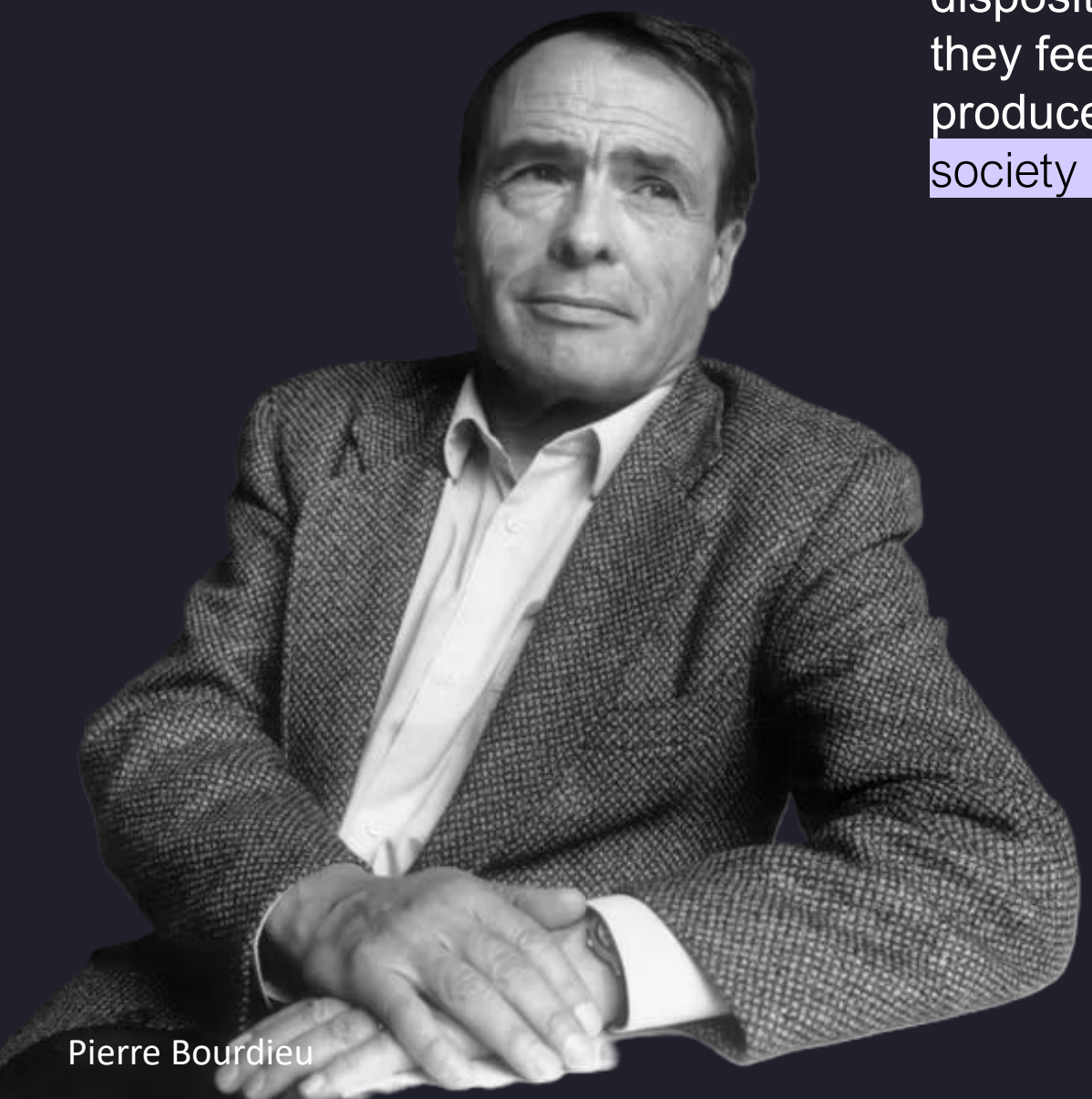
The Life Instinct: unification, the eternal return, the perpetuation and MAINTENANCE of the species, survival systems and operations, equilibrium.

B. Two basic systems: Development and Maintenance. The sourball of every revolution: after the revolution, who's going to pick up the garbage on Monday morning?
Development: pure individual creation; the new; change; progress, advance, excitement, flight or fleeing.
Maintenance: keep the dust off the pure individual creation; preserve the new; sustain the change; protect progress; defend and prolong the advance; renew the excitement; repeat the flight.

show your work--show it again
keep the contemporaryartmuseum groovy
keep the home fires burning

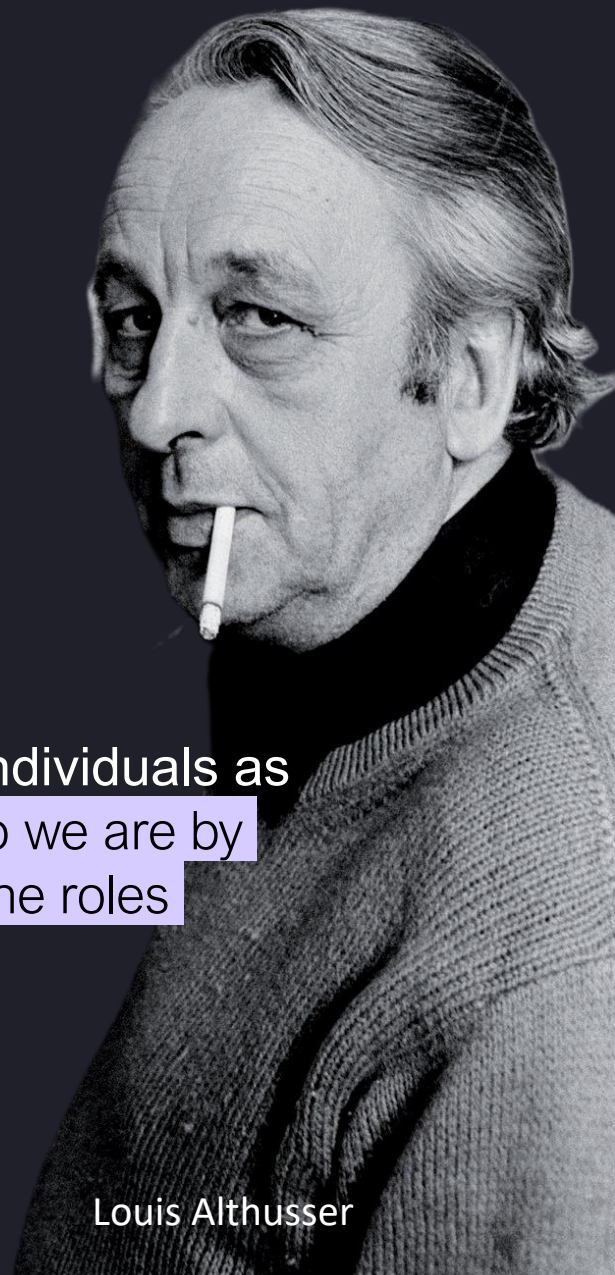
Development systems are partial feedback systems with major room for change.
Maintenance systems are direct feedback systems with little room for alteration.

Habitus — the accumulation of dispositions so deeply embodied that they feel natural rather than historically produced. The question is "How has society become part of me?"



Pierre Bourdieu

Ideology "interpellates" individuals as subjects: we become who we are by recognizing ourselves in the roles society offers us.



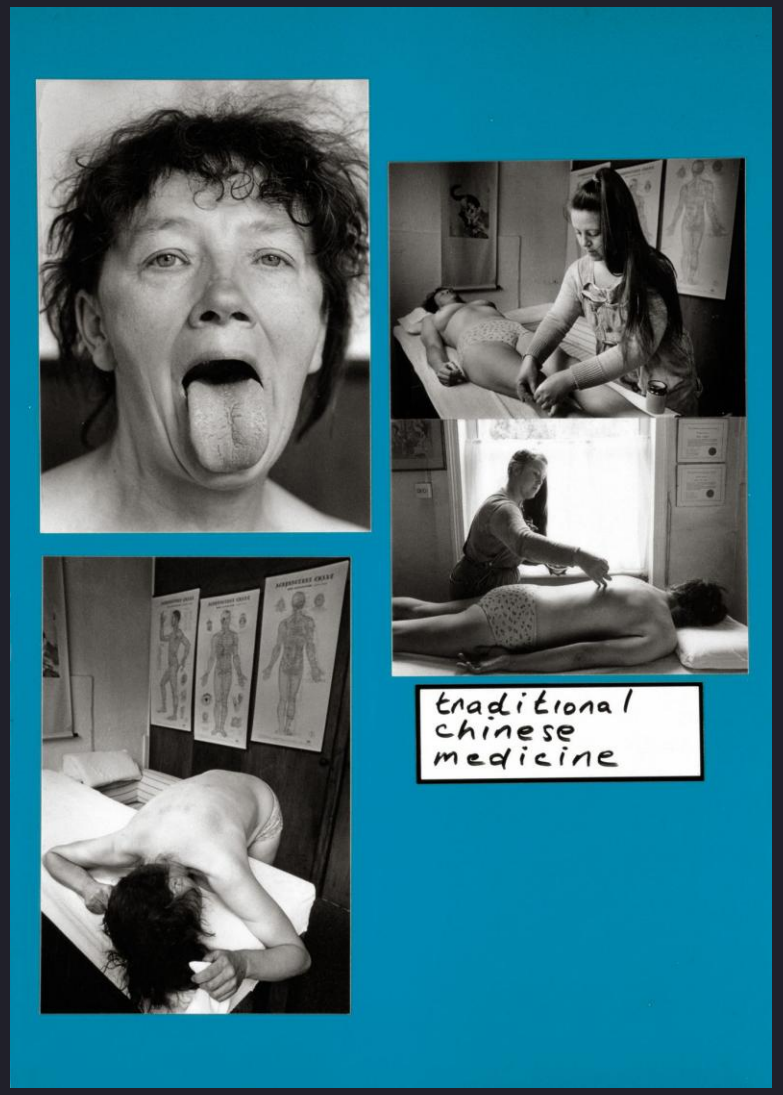
Louis Althusser



What if the structures shaping society have become part of who we are?



Kader Attia, The repair, 2014







Jo Spence,
The Picture of Health, 1982



Tania Bruguera,
Tatlin’s Whisper #6, 2009



ImageNet Roulette,
Trevor Paglen and Kate Crawford, 2020

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Art moves through three depths of inquiry — first reading symptoms society displays (folly, denial, spectacle), then exposing the structures that produce them (institutions, economics, power), then revealing how those structures become internalized as identity (habits, gestures, self-perception).
- Symptom level: Bruegel, Hogarth, Ensor, and Posada show that societies reveal their unconscious truths (vanity, decay, illusion, pretense) most clearly through ordinary people, crowds, and objects rather than idealized heroes.
- Structure level: Meireles, Ukeles race those symptoms back to hidden systems (state propaganda, undervalued labor, institutional authority) showing how power makes itself feel natural and invisible.
- Subject level: Attia, Spence, and Bruguera show that power gets absorbed into bodies, memory, and behavior, until the personal and political become indistinguishable.

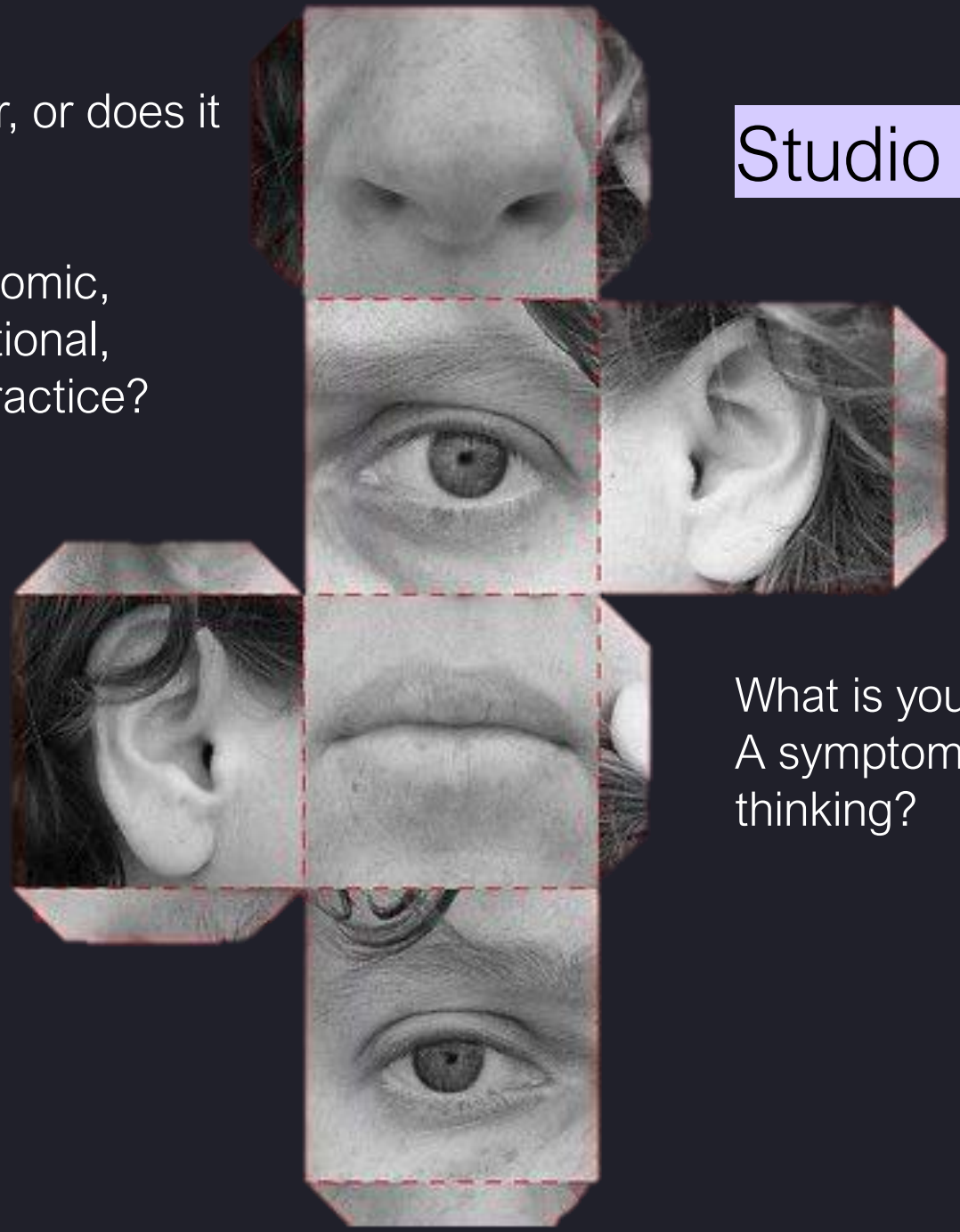
Key strategies across the examples

- The crowd and proverbs as mirror (Bruegel)
- Narrative sequence as moral pathology (Hogarth)
- The mask as revelation (Ensor)
- The skeleton as satire (Posada)
- Currency and commodity as critique
- Labor made visible (Ukeles)
- Wound and repair as memory (Attia)
- The patient's body as battleground (Spence)
- Enacted freedom as exposure (Bruguera)

Studio Reflections

Does your work expose power, or does it unintentionally reproduce it?

Which invisible systems (economic, political, technological, institutional, cultural) shape your artistic practice?



What is your work diagnosing? A symptom, a system, or a way of thinking?

STAGING

CREATING THE CONDITIONS UNDER WHICH SOCIETY REVEALS ITSELF



Art meaning emerges through the interaction between people and their environment.

John Dewey

Relational aesthetics — works that create situations for encounter, participation, and temporary social relations.

Nicolas Bourriaud



Who’s afraid of red, yellow, and green? Rirkrit Tiravanija, 2010



Thomas Hirschhorn, The Bataille Monument, 2002

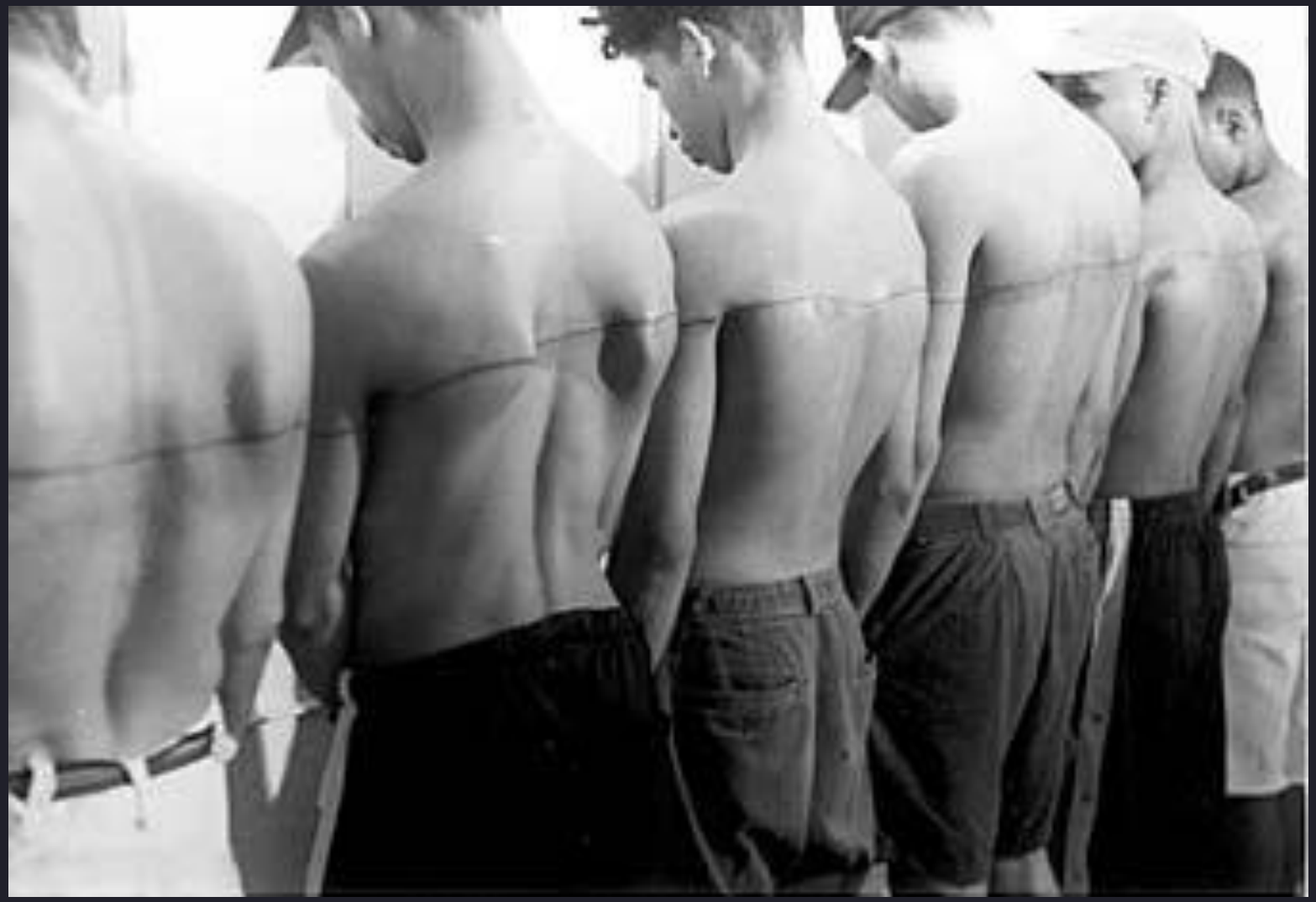


Rimini Protokoll, 100% City

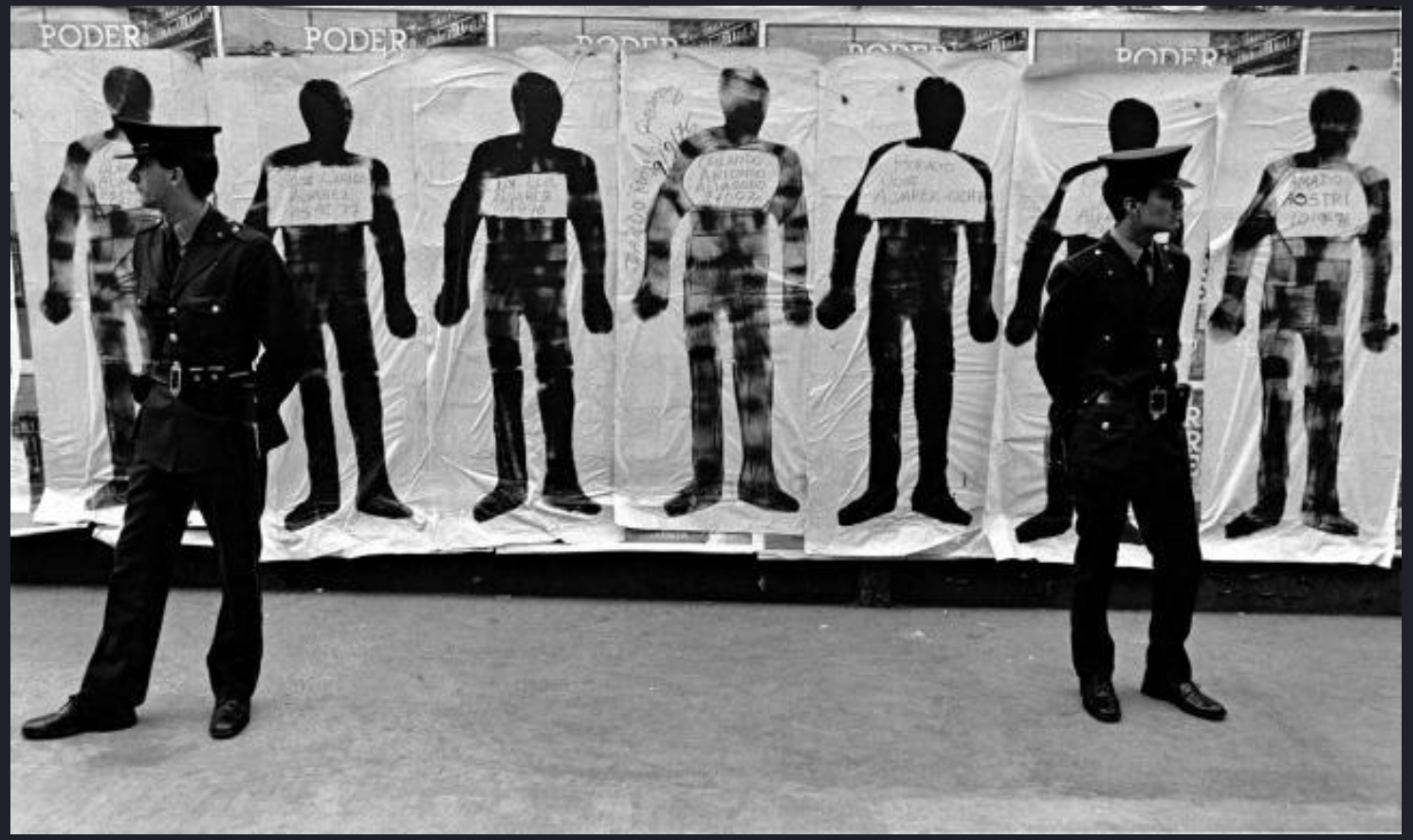




People Paid to Remain Inside Cardboard Boxes, Santiago Sierra, 1999



60 cm Line Tattooed on 4 People, Santiago Sierra, 1999





The Siluetazo (1983) and their collective method of "the presence of absence.





Jeremy Deller, The Battle of Orgreave, 2001

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- From object to situation: the artwork stops being something you look at and becomes something you enter — a set of conditions (a meal, a payment, a reenactment, a street action) that lets society reveal or produce itself through real participation.
- Strategies like Sierra's payments, Hirschhorn's cheap materials, and El Siluetazo's actual bodies work because they use real economic, physical, and emotional relationships rather than representations of them (the contract, the site, the trace all carry literal consequence).
- The public becomes the material: whether it's Tiravanija's shared meals, Rimini Protokoll's non-actor citizens, or Deller's actual former miners and police, the artists stage real people and their differences as the content of the work itself.
- Process over product: across every example, what matters is the event (the participation, the collective action, the lived encounter). Meaning is generated in real time and can't be separated from the doing.

Key strategies across the examples

- Shared experience as medium (Tiravanija)
- Money as material (Sierra)
- The population as performer (Rimini Protokoll)
- Site as philosophy (Hirschhorn)
- Collective absence made visible (El Siluetazo)
- Reenactment as unresolved history (Deller)

Studio Reflections

What kinds of encounters does your work make possible?

What kinds of conversations, behaviors, or relationships does your work provoke?



What rules or constraints could you introduce that would reveal something unexpected about human behavior?

FINAL TAKEAWAYS

- Across history, art has related to society in three distinct ways: flattering it (constructing the image a society wants to believe about itself), diagnosing it (exposing symptoms, structures, and internalized power it cannot admit to), and eliciting it (staging real conditions in which society reveals or produces itself live).

- Flattery is a mechanism that gives reality a coherent, bearable shape, softening uncertainty into belief. The same mechanism can oppress or sustain dignity. The flattery's danger lies in **how naturalized and self-sustaining it becomes.**

FINAL TAKEAWAYS

- Diagnostic art works in three depths: it reads symptoms society displays, exposes the structures producing them, and reveals how those structures become internalized as identity and behavior.

- Contemporary artists increasingly abandon representation, staging real conditions so that society would reveal itself. Here the artwork's power comes from stakes being real: real money (Sierra), real bodies (El Siluetazo), real citizens (Rimini Protokoll), real trauma reactivated (Deller).

THANK YOU!